The Bucket of Water

A snippet story

Haoyu could already hear Rex long before he reached the courtyard.

He had returned from the clinic later than he'd meant to, with an empty medicine basket over one arm and a dull ache between his shoulders. Hearing the familiar voice beyond the gate made him smile. Rex sounded exceptionally pleased with himself, and from the occasional interruptions, Soul had been trying unsuccessfully to bring whatever story he was telling to close.

"No, you're missing the important part," Rex insisted. He was standing beside the table with one hand lifted, addressing an audience that had begun to look rather worn down. "He had already seen me go through the doorway. He knew I was there."

"We know you were there too," Soul said, resting his cheek against his hand. "You've been stalling at this part for a while now."

Rex waved the objection aside. "Because you keep interrupting."

Gong lowered his eyes to his tea, trying with great effort to keep his expression composed.

Haoyu had just stepped through the gate when he noticed GNS approaching behind Rex. She carried a wooden bucket in both hands, her pale sleeves gathered out of the way. For one brief moment, Haoyu assumed there was some perfectly ordinary reason for it.

Heka saw GNS approach and sat upright.

"Master—"

GNS lifted the bucket and unceremoniously emptied it over Rex's head.

The flowed directly over Rex's head, cutting him off in the middle of a sentence. He gave a startled cry and bent forward as the rest poured over his shoulders, splashed across the stones, and caught the edge of Soul's robe.

For a moment, nobody moved.

Rex stood with his arms held slightly away from his sides. Water ran from his hair, dripped from his nose, and pattered steadily from his sleeves. His mouth was still

open, although he appeared to have forgotten what he had been saying as he sputtered to stop from swallowing the mystery water.

GNS lowered the empty bucket with an expression of quiet satisfaction.



"There," she said. "A pause."

Soul made a strangled sound behind his hand. Gong turned away, and Heka pressed her lips together, caught somewhere between disbelief and laughter.

Haoyu felt neither.

"GNS." Haoyu spoke sternly. Heka might defer to GNS as her master, but Haoyu felt no such obligation and allowed his tone to carry the weight of all the things he was too polite to say out loud.

His voice made Heka look towards the gate. Rex turned too quickly, sending another stream of water from his hair down the front of his robe.

"Haoyu," Rex said. His attempt at a welcoming smile was spoiled when he had to blink water out of his eyes. "You're back."

Haoyu set his basket on the nearest bench and crossed the courtyard.

"Yes," he said, looking Rex over before turning to GNS. "I am. What was that for?"

"He needed to stop talking," GNS replied.

"You could have asked him."

"I did."

"Then you could have walked away. You do have that ability amongst your many skills, I assume." That brought a small silence to the table. Soul lowered his hand, and Heka watched her brother with renewed attention.

GNS glanced at the bucket. "It was only water."

"And now he's wearing all of it," Haoyu said.

Rex brushed a hand across his face, looking between them. “It’s all right. I probably was getting a little carried away.”

Haoyu’s expression softened when he turned back to him.

“That doesn’t mean you needed a bucket emptied over your head.” He reached up to move a wet strand of hair away from Rex’s eyes, then stopped when he realised his own sleeve would be of little use. “Wait here. I’ll get a towel.”

“I can get one,” Rex offered.

“You’ll drip through the hall and likely catch a chill. I’ll be back in a moment.”

Haoyu went inside before Rex could object. Behind him, Soul finally let out the laugh he had been holding.



“Well,” Soul said, surveying the puddle around Rex’s feet. “You did say we weren’t listening.”

Heka stretched her leg beneath the table and nudged Soul’s ankle with her shoe.

“Perhaps leave it there,” she advised.

Haoyu returned with two towels folded over his arm. He handed one to Rex, then opened the other and laid it around his shoulders. Up close, Rex looked even more thoroughly soaked than he had from the gate. His collar clung to his neck, and water was still gathering at the ends of his hair.

“Sit down,” Haoyu said gently.

Rex obeyed, lowering himself onto the bench while Haoyu gathered the wet hair away from his collar. Haoyu folded the towel around it and pressed carefully, his brow drawn in concentration.

“Close your eyes a moment.”

Rex did. Haoyu used a dry corner to wipe the water from his forehead and temples, then passed it gently along his cheek.

“There,” Haoyu murmured. “Is that better?”

“Much.”

Rex opened his eyes and looked up at him. The dismay had begun to leave his expression, replaced by a rather pleased quietness that Soul noticed immediately.

Haoyu, occupied with drying Rex’s hair, did not.

“Are you cold?” Haoyu asked.

“A little,” Rex admitted.

Haoyu glanced over his shoulder at GNS.

She had set down the bucket and was reaching for her tea. Her hand paused when she met his eyes.



“He’ll need dry clothes,” Haoyu said.

“I imagine he has some.”

Haoyu continued looking at her.

Heka stood before the silence could become any more pointed. “I’ll run to grab it. Rex, is it still hanging beside your door?”

“Yes,” Rex replied. “Thank you.”

Heka nodded and disappeared outside in the direction of Rex’s courtyard.

Haoyu returned his attention to Rex, drawing the towel more securely around his shoulders. “You should change as soon as she gets back. You can’t sit here in wet clothes with the evening coming on.”

“I wasn’t planning to.”

“You were about to tell us the rest of the story,” Gong observed.

Rex leaned to look behind Haoyu at the others, offended. “I had nearly finished.”

Soul shut his eyes, still snickering under his breath.

Haoyu pressed his lips together. Despite himself, a small smile threatened to interrupt his displeasure. He hid it by adjusting the towel, but Rex caught it and brightened.

“It was a good story,” Rex told him.

“You can tell me when you’re dry,” Haoyu replied.

Soul looked towards Gong with the weary resignation of a man who had just seen all their progress undone.

GNS took a sip of tea. “You’re making a great fuss over him.”

Haoyu’s hands stilled. When he turned towards her, his expression was composed, but there was nothing uncertain in his voice.

“He came here to spend time with his friends. I don’t think he should have to wonder whether someone is going to drench him for talking too much.”

GNS regarded him over the rim of her cup. Haoyu held her gaze.

“If you do it again,” he added, “I will be displeased again.” His tone again carrying on the weight of his meaning.

Rex lowered his eyes to the towel in his hands, a little stunned to see this side of Haoyu and glad that it’s in his defense rather than directed at him. Beside him, Soul suddenly became very interested in brushing a drop of water from the table.

At last, GNS set down her cup.

“Very well,” she said. Then she looked at Rex. “I could have found another way to interrupt you.”

Rex gave her a cautious smile. “Feather might have been fun.”

GNS inclined her head. “I’ll try to keep some on hand in the future.”

Some of the tension left Haoyu’s shoulders. He resumed drying Rex’s hair, working through it carefully until Heka returned with a bundle of clean clothes.

“The small room off the hall is empty,” Heka said, handing them over.

Haoyu took the wet towel from Rex’s shoulders and replaced it with the drier one. “Go and change. I’ll find somewhere to hang these.”

Rex stood, then hesitated beside him.

“You’ve only just come back from the clinic,” Rex said quietly. “You haven’t even sat down.”

“I will.”

“Sit with me when I come back?”

Haoyu looked up. Rex was holding the clothes against his chest, his damp hair pushed untidily away from his face. There was something unexpectedly earnest about the request.

“Yes,” Haoyu said, his expression softening again. “Of course.”

Rex smiled and went to small side room to change.

By the time he returned, Haoyu had hung the towels over the courtyard rail and poured a fresh cup of tea. He had also moved a chair next to him and away from the evening breeze. Rex noticed the cup first, then the empty chair beside Haoyu, and went directly to it.

“Better?” Haoyu asked.

“Much better,” Rex replied. He settled into the chair and wrapped his hands around the warm cup. “Thank you for looking after me.”

Haoyu reached over to straighten the edge of the towel Rex still wore around his neck.

“You’re welcome.”

Across the courtyard, GNS picked up the empty bucket to put it away.

Haoyu’s eyes followed her immediately.

GNS stopped, looked at him, and turned the bucket upside down so he could see that it was empty.

Rex laughed into his tea.